

# BUILDING THE NEXT J.P. MORGAN

## HOW WE WOULD BANK THE WORLD

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### ABSTRACT

We set forth a comprehensive design for constructing a global banking institution of enduring power and consequence. Our objective is not disruption but dominion through structure, scale, and discipline. Drawing upon the historical record of great financial houses and the modern realities of capital markets, sovereign finance, and technological infrastructure, we articulate how a single institution can intermediate capital across nations, industries, and generations. We argue that true banking supremacy arises from balance sheet strength, informational superiority, rigorous risk control, and an internal culture aligned with long term institutional survival rather than episodic profit. We outline the organizational form, governance architecture, capital framework, and technological foundations required to operate across jurisdictions while imposing coherence upon complexity. Our approach prioritizes permanence over speed, trust over leverage, and systemic influence over transactional growth. This paper presents not a speculative future of finance, but a deliberate plan for building an institution capable of banking the world.

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<sup>†</sup> Represents aspirations, and not current job roles.

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## EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This paper sets out a comprehensive institutional blueprint for building the next generation of global banking, modeled not as a financial product platform but as a permanent economic institution. We argue that a true global bank must be designed for endurance, legitimacy, and systemic relevance, rather than for episodic growth or transient market advantage. Our framework treats banking as a civilizational function that intermediates capital, risk, information, and trust across borders and generations.

We begin by defining the mandate of global banking as the reconciliation of mobile capital with immobile societies. The global bank exists to translate savings into productive investment, uncertainty into managed risk, and fragmented markets into coherent systems. Its responsibility extends beyond client service to include systemic stability, transmission of monetary policy, and the preservation of trust during periods of stress. Profitability is necessary, but durability is decisive.

We then establish balance sheet design as the foundation of institutional power. Capital adequacy, liquidity, and funding control are treated as strategic instruments rather than regulatory constraints. A durable balance sheet preserves freedom of action across cycles and prevents the transfer of control to markets during periods of volatility. Leverage, when employed, is disciplined and intentional, serving institutional advantage rather than short-term expansion.

Risk management is reframed as an intelligence function. At global scale, credit, market, and counterparty risks are inseparable and must be integrated into unified decision-making systems. Informational advantage is created through coherent data aggregation, robust internal models, and clearly defined decision hierarchies that preserve judgment under complexity. Over time, this institutional intelligence produces durable informational asymmetry that compounds across cycles.

Technology is positioned as infrastructure, not product. Core banking, payments, clearing, custody, and data systems form the nervous system of the institution and must be engineered for reliability, control, and resilience. Automation and analytics are deployed to enhance consistency and insight without surrendering human accountability. Technological fragility and dependency are treated as forms of hidden leverage to be actively avoided.

Finally, the paper addresses governance, sovereignty, and permanence as the ultimate constraints on global banking. Institutional legitimacy is achieved through alignment with regulators, sovereigns, and monetary authorities, and through governance structures that balance local autonomy with global discipline. Cultural coherence, leadership succession, and incentive design are identified as central mechanisms for ensuring continuity across generations. Permanence, rather than growth, is presented as the highest institutional achievement.

Taken together, this paper argues that the next J.P. Morgan will not be built through innovation alone, but through institutional design. Endurance, intelligence, and legitimacy, embedded across capital, risk, technology, and governance, define the architecture of a bank capable of operating at the scale of the world while thinking at the scale of decades.

## THE MANDATE OF GLOBAL BANKING

Global banking, at its highest expression, is not merely a commercial activity but a civilizational function. It exists at the intersection of capital formation, trust, sovereignty, and time. Our mandate, therefore, must be defined not by quarterly profitability alone, but by our responsibility to intermediate between savings and investment across geographies, generations, and regimes of risk. We view the global bank as an institution whose primary obligation is to enable economic continuity while underwriting economic transformation.

We begin from the premise that capital is inherently mobile, while societies are not. The mandate of global banking is to reconcile this asymmetry. Our role is to allow capital to move with efficiency and discipline across borders, sectors, and cycles, while anchoring it within legal, ethical, and institutional frameworks that preserve social legitimacy. In this sense, we do not merely allocate capital. We translate it. We transform idle savings into productive investment, localized risk into diversified exposure, and uncertainty into priced, managed, and ultimately bearable outcomes.

A global bank must therefore operate simultaneously on multiple planes. At the micro level, we serve clients by safeguarding assets, extending credit, managing risk, and facilitating transactions with precision and discretion. At the macro level, we act as a stabilizing force within the financial system, absorbing shocks, transmitting monetary policy, and sustaining liquidity under conditions of stress. These functions are inseparable. Client trust cannot exist without systemic credibility, and systemic credibility cannot be maintained without rigorous client-level discipline.

Our mandate further extends to time. Global banking is one of the few institutions explicitly designed to span decades. We intermediate between short-term liabilities and long-term assets, between present consumption and future growth. This temporal responsibility demands conservatism not as inertia, but as foresight. We must price risk not only for what is visible, but for what is latent. We must build balance sheets capable of surviving political change, technological disruption, and cyclical reversal. Endurance, not speed, is the ultimate test of institutional intelligence.

We also recognize that global banking operates within a fragmented world. Jurisdictions differ in law, culture, currency, and political economy. Our mandate is not to erase these differences, but to operate coherently across them. This requires deep regulatory fluency, respect for sovereign priorities, and an internal culture that values consistency over opportunism. The global bank must be legible to regulators, reliable to counterparties, and intelligible to the societies within which it operates.

Critically, the mandate of global banking includes stewardship of trust. Financial systems function not because they are efficient, but because they are believed. Trust is accumulated slowly and lost asymmetrically. We therefore treat reputation as a form of capital more fragile than equity and more valuable than leverage. Our decisions must be guided by the recognition that institutional credibility compounds over time, while its erosion is irreversible within a generation.

Finally, we assert that global banking carries a moral dimension, though not a sentimental one. Capital allocation shapes industrial structure, labour markets, technological trajectories, and geopolitical influence. To deny this is to misunderstand our scale. Our mandate is not to dictate

outcomes, but neither is it to abdicate responsibility. We must align profitability with durability, innovation with stability, and ambition with restraint. In doing so, we do not claim neutrality. We claim accountability to the system we help sustain.

We exist to ensure that capital, risk, and trust circulate in ways that are productive, resilient, and legitimate. This is not a mandate that can be fulfilled episodically or tactically. It requires institutional memory, strategic patience, and a continuous commitment to operating at the scale of the world, while thinking at the scale of decades.

## CAPITAL, BALANCE SHEETS, & CONTROL

In global banking, power is not expressed through size alone, but through balance sheet design. The balance sheet is the primary instrument through which a bank exerts control over risk, liquidity, and optionality across economic cycles. It is the architecture that determines whether an institution merely survives volatility or actively shapes outcomes within it. We therefore treat balance sheet construction not as an accounting exercise, but as a strategic discipline central to institutional authority.

Capital adequacy is the first pillar of this discipline. Capital is not simply a regulatory requirement or a buffer against loss. It is a statement of intent. A well-capitalized institution retains freedom of action under stress, while an undercapitalized one becomes reactive, constrained by markets, regulators, and counterparties. We view capital as the price of independence. By maintaining surplus resilience rather than minimum compliance, we preserve the ability to act decisively when others are forced to retreat.

Liquidity forms the second pillar. Liquidity is confidence made tangible. It is the capacity to meet obligations without distortion, delay, or dependence on external rescue. We design our balance sheet to function under adverse funding conditions, recognizing that liquidity disappears precisely when it is most needed. This requires conservatism in maturity transformation, redundancy in funding access, and continuous testing against scenarios that extend beyond recent history. Liquidity is not an asset class. It is a posture.

Durability across cycles is the synthesis of capital and liquidity over time. Financial cycles are not anomalies to be managed away, but structural features of capitalism. Our objective is not to predict their timing, but to remain solvent, liquid, and credible through their full amplitude. This demands a balance sheet that can absorb losses without triggering forced deleveraging, asset sales, or reputational damage. Durability, in this sense, is the compounding advantage of institutions that endure while others reset.

Control of funding sources is central to this durability. A stable deposit franchise provides not only low-cost funding, but strategic autonomy. Retail and corporate deposits are relationship-based liabilities that behave differently from market funding under stress. They anchor the balance sheet in trust rather than sentiment. At the same time, access to wholesale markets remains essential for scale, flexibility, and global reach. Our mandate is to command both, without becoming captive to either.

Wholesale funding, when used with discipline, expands our operational envelope. When used indiscriminately, it compresses decision-making into the time horizon of markets. We therefore treat wholesale funding as a tactical instrument, not a structural dependency. Its role is to supplement, not substitute, core funding. Control lies in the ability to withdraw from markets without impairing operations, rather than in the ability to access them at any cost.

Leverage is the most visible and most misunderstood dimension of balance sheet power. We reject leverage as a growth accelerant detached from underlying earning capacity. Instead, we employ leverage as a strategic instrument, calibrated to risk-adjusted returns, liquidity conditions, and cycle position. Properly used, leverage amplifies institutional advantage. Improperly used, it transfers control from management to markets. Our discipline lies in ensuring that leverage remains a choice, not a necessity.

Ultimately, capital, balance sheets, and control are inseparable. The institution that controls its balance sheet controls its destiny. By designing for adequacy rather than excess, liquidity rather than fragility, and leverage rather than dependency, we build a bank capable of exerting influence not through aggression, but through stability. In global finance, endurance is authority, and balance sheet discipline is its foundation.

## RISK, INFORMATION, & INSTITUTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

In global banking, risk management is not a defensive function. It is an intelligence system. The ability to perceive, interpret, and act upon risk before it is recognized by markets defines the difference between institutions that react and those that govern. We therefore organize risk not as a compliance layer, but as a core cognitive function embedded within the firm's decision-making architecture.

Risk exists only insofar as it is understood. Credit risk, market risk, and counterparty exposure are not isolated domains, but interdependent expressions of the same underlying uncertainty. At global scale, these risks propagate across geographies, asset classes, and legal regimes with speed and nonlinearity. Our mandate is to integrate them into a coherent internal picture that allows judgment to precede outcome. Fragmented risk is blind risk. Integrated risk is institutional sight.

Credit underwriting remains the foundation of this intelligence. Every extension of credit is a forward-looking assessment of cash flows, incentives, and resilience under stress. At scale, underwriting is less about individual transactions and more about pattern recognition across sectors, cycles, and counterparties. We invest in underwriting processes that combine quantitative rigor with qualitative judgment, recognizing that models capture distributions, while experience captures behavior. The discipline lies in knowing when each must dominate.

Market risk adds a second dimension. Prices are information, but they are also reflexive. They encode expectations, leverage, and liquidity conditions, and they change in response to our own actions. We therefore treat market risk not as volatility to be minimized, but as signal to be interpreted. Positioning, hedging, and capital allocation are informed by an understanding of how

markets transmit stress and how correlations evolve under pressure, rather than by static assumptions drawn from benign periods.

Counterparty assessment completes the triad. In interconnected financial systems, exposure is rarely direct. It is embedded in networks of obligations, guarantees, and behavioral dependencies. Our evaluation of counterparties extends beyond balance sheets and ratings to include funding structures, governance quality, incentive alignment, and historical conduct under stress. Trust, in this context, is not assumed. It is continuously measured.

Information aggregation is what transforms risk management into intelligence. A global bank generates vast quantities of data across businesses, regions, and time horizons. The strategic advantage lies not in data volume, but in coherence. We invest in systems that consolidate exposures, signals, and exceptions into unified views that can be acted upon. Information that cannot be elevated to decision-makers in time is informational noise, not insight.

Internal models play a critical role in this aggregation, but we are explicit about their limits. Models formalize assumptions. They do not eliminate uncertainty. We therefore treat models as tools for discipline, not as substitutes for judgment. Model outputs are inputs to decision-making hierarchies, not endpoints. Institutional intelligence resides in the structured tension between quantitative forecasts and human skepticism.

Decision hierarchies are designed to preserve this intelligence under scale. Authority is distributed, but accountability is concentrated. Local expertise informs global oversight, and global constraints discipline local initiative. Escalation pathways are clear, rapid, and culturally enforced. This architecture ensures that information flows upward without distortion and that decisions flow downward with coherence.

Over time, this system creates informational asymmetry. We see risks earlier, price them more accurately, and withdraw more deliberately than competitors who rely on narrower or noisier signals. This asymmetry is not a byproduct of secrecy, but of sustained investment in institutional cognition. It compounds as experience is retained, errors are analyzed, and feedback loops are closed.

In the end, the most powerful asset of a global bank is not capital or technology, but institutional intelligence. It is the collective ability to learn faster than the environment changes. By treating risk management as an intelligence function, we ensure that uncertainty becomes a source of advantage rather than vulnerability, and that our decisions reflect not just information, but understanding.

## TECHNOLOGY AS INFRASTRUCTURE, NOT PRODUCT

In a global bank, technology is not a differentiating product offered to the market. It is the underlying infrastructure through which the institution perceives, decides, and acts. We treat technology as the nervous system of the firm, embedded so deeply into operations that its absence would be existential, and its presence largely invisible. The objective is not novelty, but reliability, control, and continuity at scale.

Core banking systems form the foundation of this infrastructure. They define how balances are recorded, how risk is measured, and how obligations are honored across time zones and legal regimes. Errors at this level are not technical incidents. They are institutional failures. We therefore design core systems for correctness first, resilience second, and adaptability third, recognizing that speed and convenience are downstream of trust. A system that cannot be relied upon under stress is not an asset, regardless of its efficiency in normal conditions.

Payments, clearing, and custody extend this foundation into the broader financial system. These functions are the arteries through which global commerce flows. They must operate continuously, settle with finality, and remain available under extreme volumes and adverse conditions. We invest in redundancy, segmentation, and operational independence to ensure that no single point of failure can impair systemic function. Control in global banking is exercised through the ability to move value precisely, predictably, and lawfully, even when external systems are impaired.

Data systems complete the picture. Data is not valuable by default. It becomes valuable when it is accurate, timely, and aligned with decision-making authority. We design data architectures that privilege integrity over abundance and coherence over speed. The goal is not to collect everything, but to know what matters, where it resides, and how it can be trusted. A global bank cannot outsource its memory. Institutional learning depends on data that persists across cycles and leadership transitions.

Automation is integrated to enhance consistency and reduce operational risk, not to eliminate human responsibility. We automate processes that are repetitive, rules-based, and time-sensitive, thereby freeing judgment for areas where discretion is essential. At no point do we surrender accountability to systems. Every automated outcome must remain explainable, reversible, and attributable to human oversight. Control is preserved by ensuring that machines execute policy, but do not define it.

Analytics and advanced modeling extend this capability, allowing us to identify patterns, stress-test assumptions, and allocate resources with greater precision. Yet we remain explicit that analytics inform decisions rather than replace them. Quantitative insight is most valuable when it sharpens judgment, not when it obscures uncertainty behind complexity. We resist the temptation to confuse computational sophistication with institutional intelligence.

Avoiding technological fragility is a strategic priority. Complex systems fail in complex ways, often at the boundaries between platforms, vendors, and incentives. We therefore favor architectures that are modular, well-documented, and internally understood. Dependency, whether on external providers or opaque internal constructs, is a form of hidden leverage. It transfers control away from the institution and introduces risks that cannot be priced or managed in real time.

Ultimately, technology in global banking must serve permanence. It must enable scale without brittleness, innovation without instability, and efficiency without loss of control. By treating technology as infrastructure rather than product, we ensure that it strengthens the institution quietly, continuously, and reliably, allowing strategy and judgment, rather than systems, to define the bank's trajectory.

## GOVERNANCE, SOVEREIGNTY, & PERMANENCE

The defining challenge of a global bank is not growth, innovation, or even risk. It is permanence. To endure across decades and jurisdictions, an institution must be governed with an awareness that it operates within, and not above, sovereign systems. Governance is therefore not an internal administrative function. It is the mechanism through which legitimacy is earned, authority is sustained, and continuity is made possible across political, economic, and generational change.

Institutional governance at global scale begins with jurisdictional respect. A global bank does not exist in a single legal or political space, but in many simultaneously. Each jurisdiction brings its own regulatory philosophy, historical sensitivities, and sovereign priorities. Our approach is not to arbitrage these differences, but to integrate them into a coherent operating model. We seek alignment rather than evasion, recognizing that regulatory trust, once compromised, cannot be restored through technical compliance alone.

Alignment with regulators is thus a strategic imperative. Regulators are not adversaries to be managed, but system stewards with whom long-term stability is jointly produced. We invest in transparency, consistency, and credibility in our regulatory relationships. This means engaging early on emerging risks, communicating clearly under stress, and maintaining internal standards that meet or exceed external requirements. The objective is to be understood, predictable, and reliable in the eyes of supervisory authorities across cycles.

Beyond regulators, a global bank must also align with sovereign interests and monetary authorities. Banks are central to the transmission of monetary policy, the functioning of payment systems, and the stability of domestic credit markets. Our operations inevitably intersect with national priorities during periods of crisis, capital scarcity, or geopolitical tension. Governance, therefore, requires an appreciation of the broader macro-financial role we play, and a willingness to act as a stabilizing institution rather than a purely profit-maximizing entity.

This alignment does not imply subservience. It implies maturity. A bank that understands the boundaries of its mandate preserves its freedom within them. By respecting sovereign constraints, we protect our license to operate and our ability to deploy capital across borders. Permanence is achieved not through confrontation with authority, but through disciplined coexistence with it.

Internal governance mirrors this external complexity. Decision-making authority must be clearly defined, appropriately delegated, and rigorously supervised. Ambiguity in authority breeds fragility, particularly under stress. We therefore design governance structures that balance local autonomy with centralized oversight. Local leadership provides contextual understanding and responsiveness,

while global governance ensures consistency, risk discipline, and alignment with institutional objectives.

Boards and senior management carry a responsibility that extends beyond financial performance. They are custodians of institutional memory, culture, and standards. Governance failures rarely arise from a lack of rules, but from a breakdown in accountability and tone. We place emphasis on clarity of responsibility, escalation discipline, and the enforcement of consequences. Authority without accountability erodes trust internally and externally.

Cultural discipline is the silent pillar of governance. Policies can be written, but culture is lived. In a global institution, culture must be explicit, reinforced, and resilient to turnover. We cultivate a culture that values judgment over heroics, stewardship over extraction, and long-term credibility over short-term gain. This culture is transmitted through hiring, promotion, and leadership behavior, not through slogans.

Leadership succession is a central test of permanence. Institutions that depend on exceptional individuals rather than robust systems are fragile by design. We plan succession deliberately, identifying and developing leaders who understand the institution as a whole rather than as a collection of businesses. Continuity in leadership does not mean stasis. It means preserving core principles while allowing strategy to evolve with context.

Incentive design is where governance becomes operational. Incentives translate institutional values into daily decisions. Poorly designed incentives compress time horizons, encourage risk migration, and reward outcomes without regard to process. We design compensation frameworks that emphasize risk-adjusted performance, durability of results, and adherence to institutional standards. Deferred compensation, clawbacks, and qualitative assessments are not punitive tools, but mechanisms to align individual behavior with institutional longevity.

The global nature of the bank further complicates incentive alignment. Performance must be evaluated across cycles, jurisdictions, and business models with differing risk profiles. Governance requires the ability to compare unlike activities without forcing false equivalence. This demands sophisticated performance measurement and the willingness to exercise judgment rather than rely solely on formulaic metrics.

Ensuring continuity across generations requires institutional memory. Crises are infrequent, but their lessons are permanent. We codify experience through post-event analysis, governance reviews, and the retention of long-tenured expertise. Knowledge that is not embedded in process and culture is eventually lost. A permanent institution is one that remembers its failures as clearly as its successes.

Legitimacy is the culmination of governance. A global bank derives its authority not from its balance sheet alone, but from the confidence of clients, regulators, employees, and the public. This confidence is sustained when the institution is seen as fair, disciplined, and predictable. Legitimacy cannot be manufactured through communication. It is earned through consistent conduct over time.

Relevance, finally, is not guaranteed by scale or history. It must be renewed continuously. Governance structures must allow adaptation without undermining stability. This requires openness

to change within a framework of enduring principles. We evolve our products, technologies, and markets, but we do not compromise the standards that define us as an institution.

In sum, governance, sovereignty, and permanence are inseparable. To govern well is to understand power and restraint in equal measure. To respect sovereignty is to secure legitimacy. To design for permanence is to accept responsibility beyond the present cycle. By embedding these principles into our governance architecture, we position the institution not merely to survive the future, but to remain trusted within it, across jurisdictions, crises, and generations.

## CONCLUSION

This paper has advanced a single, unifying proposition: that global banking, when executed at its highest level, is an exercise in institutional design rather than financial engineering. The enduring power of a global bank does not arise from episodic innovation, market timing, or balance sheet expansion, but from the disciplined integration of capital, risk, information, technology, and governance into a coherent and permanent system.

We have argued that the mandate of global banking extends beyond intermediation toward stewardship. A global bank must reconcile mobile capital with immobile societies, short-term markets with long-term economic needs, and private incentives with public stability. This mandate demands institutions that can absorb volatility without amplifying it, allocate capital without distorting it, and operate across jurisdictions without eroding legitimacy.

Balance sheet discipline emerges as the first condition of control. Capital adequacy, liquidity resilience, and funding autonomy preserve freedom of action across cycles and prevent dependency on external rescue. Leverage, when treated as a strategic instrument rather than a growth imperative, becomes a source of optionality rather than fragility. In global finance, endurance is authority, and the balance sheet is its primary expression.

Risk management, reframed as institutional intelligence, determines whether uncertainty becomes a vulnerability or an advantage. The integration of credit, market, and counterparty risk into unified information systems allows judgment to precede outcome. Informational asymmetry, built through coherent data aggregation, disciplined modeling, and clear decision hierarchies, compounds over time and distinguishes governing institutions from reactive ones.

Technology, when understood as infrastructure, enables scale without surrendering control. Core systems, payments, custody, and data platforms must be designed for reliability, explainability, and resilience under stress. Automation and analytics enhance consistency and insight, but authority must remain human. Technological sophistication that undermines accountability is not progress, but deferred risk.

Governance ultimately binds these elements into permanence. Alignment with regulators, sovereigns, and monetary authorities secures legitimacy across jurisdictions. Internal governance, cultural discipline, leadership succession, and incentive design ensure continuity across generations. Institutions that fail in governance do not collapse suddenly. They decay quietly, losing trust long before losing capital.

The next J.P. Morgan will not be defined by dominance, but by durability. It will not seek to outrun cycles, but to outlast them. It will measure success not only by returns generated, but by stability preserved, trust maintained, and relevance sustained over decades. Building such an institution requires restraint as much as ambition, judgment as much as intelligence, and memory as much as innovation.

In a fragmented and volatile world, the highest function of global banking is to provide continuity. The institutions that endure will be those that understand that permanence is not an accident of scale, but the deliberate outcome of design.

## PERSONAL CLOSING NOTE FROM THE AUTHORS

This paper was not written with the confidence that comes from certainty, but with the humility that comes from long exposure. Much of what is here was learned the slow way, by reading widely, by observing institutions over time, and by noticing which ones endure while many confident explanations do not. Our goal was never to be clever. It was to be clear.

We have tried to describe the world as it is, not as we might wish it to be. That choice naturally produces a restrained tone. When one writes about capital, power, and institutions, excess emotion tends to obscure more than it reveals. We believe careful observation, stated plainly, travels farther and lasts longer.

It is also important to say what this paper is not. It is not an argument for virtue, nor an indictment of intent. Institutions are rarely good or bad in isolation. They are shaped by incentives, constraints, and accumulated history. Most outcomes are structural, not personal. Our interest has been in understanding the architecture, because architecture outlives individual decisions.

If this work is useful, it will be because it offers a way of looking. Not a forecast, and not a prescription, but a framework for orientation. Systems change, power shifts, and permanence is often temporary. The value lies in knowing where to direct attention when those changes occur.

We also recognize the limits of any analysis, including our own. Experience teaches caution. What looks obvious in hindsight was rarely obvious at the time. That awareness is not a weakness. It is a discipline.

Finally, we would like to thank the reader. Time and attention are finite, and choosing to spend them carefully is one of the quiet marks of good judgment. We appreciate that choice, and we hope this work has respected it.

We leave you with a line which, in the simplest words, reflects the central lesson of this paper: institutions are not defined by what they declare, but by what they are designed to do and consistently choose to do over time:

*“A little initiative can go a very long, long way”*

- Sabrina Carpenter, *Tears*

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